

COLLECTION · LIFE SITUATIONS

First Home Purchase for Newcomers

*Buying in Quebec when you come from elsewhere
— key steps and local rules*

READ BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Important notice

This guide is provided for informational and educational purposes only. It offers general information about real estate in Quebec and does not constitute personalized real estate, legal, tax or financial advice. As every real estate situation is different, it is recommended that you consult the appropriate professionals before making any decision regarding a real estate transaction.

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First Home Purchase for Newcomers

Buying in Quebec when you come from elsewhere — key steps and local rules

Buying a first property in Quebec when you've just arrived comes with particular challenges: building local credit, understanding a different system, and navigating vocabulary and rules specific to the province. With good support, it's entirely accessible.

This guide gives newcomers key markers: credit and financing, Québec specifics, and the steps to prepare.

Informational content. Each chapter ends with a lined “My notes” page.

Buying a first property in Quebec as a newcomer comes with particular challenges: building local credit, understanding a different system, learning a specific vocabulary. With good support, it's entirely accessible. This guide gives the key markers.

Informational content: validate your situation with the relevant professionals.

CHAPTER

Building your credit and financing file

Making yourself financeable in the local system.

Lenders look at your **Canadian credit**, your income and your stability. A local credit history can take time to build.

- Start building credit early (a card, on-time payments).
- Gather proof of income and employment.
- Explore **newcomer programs**, with particular conditions.

The more solid and documented your file, the simpler and more advantageous the financing will be.

Lenders look at your Canadian credit, your income and your stability. A local history takes time to build: open a card as soon as you arrive and pay it in full every month. Some newcomer programs offer suitable conditions, through a mortgage broker.

EMILIE'S TIP

Open a credit card as soon as you arrive and pay it in full every month. Building a Canadian history takes months: start well before you think about buying.

CHAPTER

Understanding the Québec specifics

Learning the local rules of the game.

The Quebec system has its particularities, often different from what exists elsewhere:

- The role of the **notary** (mandatory) and the **broker** (governed by the OACIQ).
- **Welcome Tax**, municipal and school taxes.
- Co-ownership **divided/undivided**, leases and rental rules if a plex.
- Building particularities (clay soils, French drain, heating, winter).

Understanding them in advance avoids many costly surprises.

The Quebec system has its particularities: a mandatory notary, a broker governed by the OACIQ, the Welcome Tax, divided/undivided co-ownership, leases if a plex, and building stock specific to the climate (clay soils, French drain, winter). Learning the local vocabulary already avoids half the mistakes.

EMILIE'S TIP

Take the time to learn the local vocabulary: “Welcome Tax”, “location certificate”, “conditions of the promise to purchase”. Understanding the words already avoids half the mistakes.

CHAPTER

Preparing and getting good support

Moving forward with confidence.

Like any first-time buyer, lay the foundations:

- Set a realistic **budget**.
- Get a mortgage **pre-approval**.
- Define your **criteria** and your areas.

As a bonus, surround yourself with professionals who understand your journey (broker, mortgage broker, notary). Learning the local market before buying is an investment that pays off.

Like any first-time buyer, lay the foundations: a realistic budget, a pre-approval, criteria and areas. As a bonus, surround yourself with professionals used to supporting newcomers — a good broker will explain not only the houses, but the whole system around them.

EMILIE'S TIP

Choose professionals used to supporting newcomers. A good broker will explain not only the houses, but the whole system around them — that's invaluable.

CHAPTER

The down payment and the available help

Gathering and optimizing your contribution.

The minimum **down payment** depends on the property's price; below a certain threshold, **loan insurance** is added to the financing.

- Save early and automate your contributions.
- Check your eligibility for **assistance programs** and incentives (depending on your status and situation).
- A family **gift** is accepted with a gift letter.

A mortgage broker can help you assemble it all in the most advantageous way.

The minimum down payment depends on the price; under 20%, loan insurance is added. Save early, check your eligibility for assistance programs, and know that a family gift is accepted with a gift letter. A mortgage broker helps you assemble it all advantageously.

EMILIE'S TIP

Look into the programs for first-time buyers and newcomers: some offer advantageous conditions. A mortgage broker knows the ones you're entitled to.

CHAPTER

From the search to taking possession

Following the journey step by step.

Once financed and well supported, the buying journey follows a clear logic:

1. **Visit** according to your criteria and areas.
2. Make a **promise to purchase** with the right conditions (financing, inspection).
3. Carry out the **inspection** and fulfill the conditions.
4. Sign at the **notary** and take possession.

At each step, ask your questions: no one expects a newcomer to already know the whole system.

The journey follows a clear logic: visit according to your criteria, make a promise to purchase with the right conditions (financing, inspection), fulfill the conditions after the inspection, then sign at the notary. At each step, ask your questions: no one expects a newcomer to already know everything.

EMILIE'S TIP

Don't be afraid to ask "too many" questions. A good professional would a thousand times rather answer your questions than see you sign without understanding. It's your biggest purchase.

IN PRACTICE

Action plan

Your next steps, concretely.

This week

1. Start or consolidate my Canadian credit.
2. Gather my proof of income and employment.

Within 30 days

1. Meet a mortgage broker (newcomer programs).
2. Learn about the Québec specifics.

Next

1. Get a pre-approval and start my search with Emilie.

To prepare

1. Build my Canadian credit and gather my proof of income.
2. Meet a mortgage broker (newcomer programs) and get a pre-approval.

REFERENCES

Resources & glossary

- Canadian credit: local history, the key to financing.
 - Newcomer programs: suitable loan conditions, through a broker.
 - OACIQ: the body governing real estate brokers.
 - Welcome Tax: municipal transfer duties.
 - Pre-approval: a confirmed amount and rate before shopping.
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- Canadian credit: local history, the key to financing.
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GOING FURTHER

Quiz — test your knowledge

1. Lenders mainly look at:

- A) Your credit from another country
- B) Your Canadian credit, your income and your stability
- C) Your age
- D) Your hobbies

2. To build local credit, you must:

- A) Wait ten years
- B) Start early (a card, on-time payments)
- C) Avoid all credit
- D) Pay cash

3. In Quebec, the notary is:

- A) Optional
- B) Mandatory for the sale
- C) Forbidden
- D) The seller

4. The Welcome Tax is:

- A) A gift
- B) Municipal transfer duties
- C) An insurance
- D) A rent

5. Before shopping, it's wise to have:

- A) No preparation
- B) A budget and a pre-approval
- C) A single visit
- D) A mover

6. Getting good support means choosing pros who:

- A) Ignore your journey
- B) Understand the newcomer journey
- C) Talk fast
- D) Don't answer

7. Below a certain down-payment threshold:

- A) The purchase is forbidden
- B) Loan insurance is added to the financing
- C) The taxes disappear
- D) The notary is free

8. A family gift for the down payment:

- A) Is refused
- B) Is accepted with a gift letter
- C) Doubles the taxes
- D) Is illegal

9. A prudent promise to purchase includes:

- A) No conditions
- B) Conditions (financing, inspection)
- C) A secret price
- D) Nothing

10. For a newcomer, asking questions is:

- A) Embarrassing
- B) Normal and encouraged
- C) Forbidden
- D) Useless

Answer key

- 1. **B** — Canadian credit (ch. 1).
- 2. **B** — Start early (ch. 1).
- 3. **B** — A mandatory notary (ch. 2).
- 4. **B** — Transfer duties (ch. 2).
- 5. **B** — Budget + pre-approval (ch. 3).
- 6. **B** — Suitable support (ch. 3).
- 7. **B** — Loan insurance (ch. 4).
- 8. **B** — A gift letter (ch. 4).

9. **B** — Protective conditions (ch. 5).

10. **B** — No one expects them to know everything (ch. 5).

Signé PAR Em

*Thank you for reading. May this guide help you
decide with confidence, with all the information
in hand.*

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